Haul

github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul-windows

Gabriel Castiglia · November 9, 2026 · version 1.5.0 · GPL-2.0 license · built and tested with yt-dlp 2026.08.19

English · Español

Repository: https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul-windows

macOS version: https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul

PDF manual: `docs/Haul-manual-en.pdf`

Haul is a Windows app that works as a front end for yt-dlp. The app builds the command, shows the progress and manages a download queue. The actual work is done by yt-dlp, bundled with the app at a fixed, verified version, and by ffmpeg. It is the Windows sibling of the macOS app of the same name: same features, same formats, same behavior. The window is always dark, with the Windows accent color, and the interface is available in English and Spanish; it starts in the language chosen in the setup window, or in English, and remembers the choice.

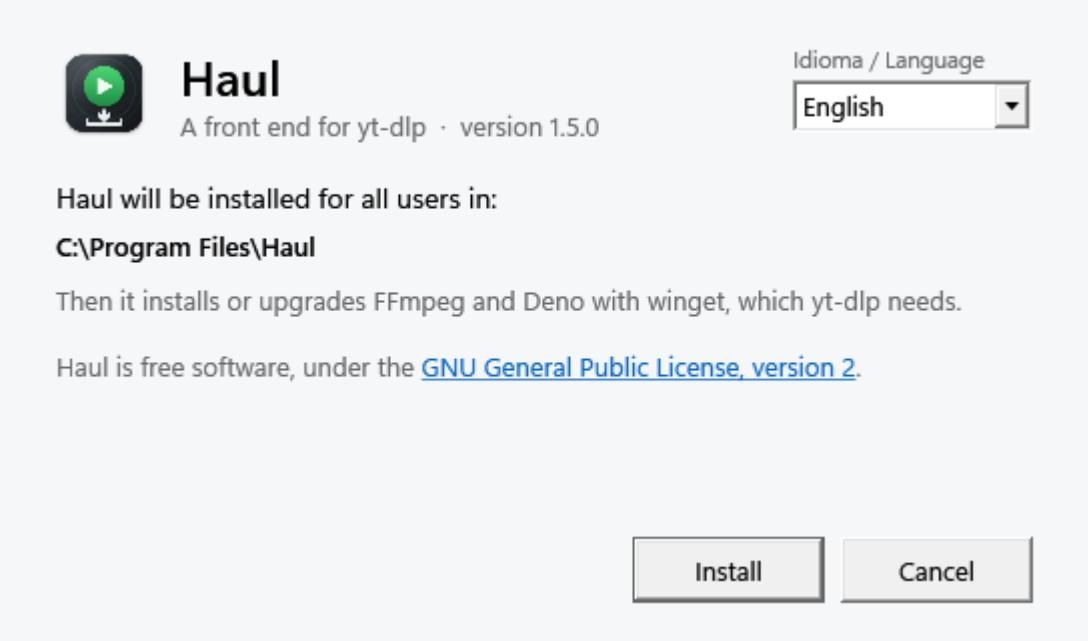
Requirements

- Windows 11, or Windows 10 version 1809 or later, on a 64-bit PC. Tested on Windows 11 Pro.
- winget (the "App Installer" from the Microsoft Store, included in Windows 11), which the setup program uses to install FFmpeg and Deno.

yt-dlp ships with the app, and Haul carries its own .NET runtime, so nothing has to be installed by hand.

Installation

Download `haul-setup.exe` from the releases page and run it. The setup window has a language menu in its top right corner, and every page changes language at once. It installs Haul for all users in `C:\Program Files\Haul`, which takes administrator rights (Windows asks for them when installation starts), and adds Haul to the Start menu. Then, as the user who ran it, it installs FFmpeg and Deno with winget, or upgrades them if they are already there; yt-dlp needs FFmpeg to join picture and sound and to convert to MP3, and Deno to solve JavaScript challenges. The language chosen in the setup window is the one Haul uses when it starts for the first time.



File	What it is
`haul-setup.exe`	Setup program, in English or Spanish. The usual way to install.
`haul.msi`	The same installation as a Windows Installer package, for silent installs: `msiexec /i haul.msi /qn`. It does not install FFmpeg and Deno; install them with `winget install yt-dlp.FFmpeg DenoLand.Deno`.

Running a newer `haul-setup.exe` updates an installed Haul and keeps each user's settings. If Haul is running, setup closes it before replacing its files. An installation made with the scripts of version 1.4 or earlier (in `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Programs\Haul`) is removed, keeping its settings, so only one Haul remains. An older version cannot be installed over a newer one.

The files are not signed with a commercial certificate, so the first time Windows SmartScreen may show "Windows protected your PC". "More info" → "Run anyway" opens them. The `SHA256SUMS.txt` file of each release lets you check the download first: `Get-FileHash haul-setup.exe`.

Uninstallation

Open Settings → Apps → Installed apps, find Haul and choose Uninstall. The same setup window opens, with its language menu. It closes Haul if it is running and removes the program and the Start menu shortcut. Downloaded files and each user's settings (`%APPDATA%\Haul`) are kept, and FFmpeg and Deno stay installed, because other programs may use them; `winget uninstall yt-dlp.FFmpeg DenoLand.Deno` removes them.

Usage

1. Paste one or more links into the box at the top. Links can be pasted on their own, one per line, or inside text copied from somewhere else; the app extracts them and drops duplicates. When the app opens or comes to the front with the box empty, it picks up the links on the clipboard.
2. Choose the format: Video (MP4) or Audio only (MP3).
3. Choose the destination folder. The first time it is Downloads; after that the app keeps the last folder chosen, and the format too.
4. Press Download or Ctrl+Enter. The box empties when the download starts, and a link already in the queue is not picked up again from the clipboard.

Links go into a queue and are downloaded one at a time. More links can be added while the queue runs. Each row shows the thumbnail, title, percentage, speed and time remaining, and once finished it offers to show the file in File Explorer or open it. Failed or cancelled downloads can be retried or removed. A cancelled download deletes the partial files it had created; files that were already in the folder, such as an earlier download of the same video in another format, are never touched.

Any row can be paused with its pause button and continued with its play button; the partial files stay on disk meanwhile, so the download picks up where it stopped. "Pause all", above the queue, holds the whole queue: the running download stops and waits first in line until "Resume all". "Retry all" appears when some download failed and starts every failed one again. Rows can be dragged with the mouse to change their order, and downloads start in the order of the list.

A download that fails is tried again up to four times, two seconds apart, and the row shows which attempt is running ("Retry 2/4"). Partial files are kept between attempts, so yt-dlp resumes where it stopped. When a download finishes, the app also deletes the intermediate files yt-dlp could not remove by itself, such as the original audio of an MP3 while a file sync client held it open.

The "Clear finished automatically" checkbox, below the format, is always in view, even with an empty queue. While it is checked, every download that finishes or is cancelled leaves the list by itself, and the summary keeps counting it; failed ones stay, so they can be retried. Checking it also clears what had already finished. The app remembers the setting.

Videos with "instrumental" in the title wait in the queue, paused, unless "Download instrumentals" is checked. A paused row can be downloaded on its own with its download button, and checking the option resumes all of them.

The ⓘ button in the window shows the version, the meaning of the name, the author, the license and the link to this repository, in the interface language. Everything from the header down to the Download button stays fixed; only the queue scrolls, so adding links never moves the window.

The app can also be started with links from a terminal or a shortcut:

```
"%LOCALAPPDATA%\Programs\Haul\Haul.exe" --descargar URL1 URL2
```

Playlists

A playlist link or a channel page is read first, without downloading anything, and every video becomes its own row in the queue, with its thumbnail and its position ("Mix · 3/12"). The files go into a subfolder named after the playlist and are numbered in playlist order: `01 – Title.mp4`, `02 – Title.mp4`, and so on. Each video can be cancelled or retried on its own. A playlist with more than 200 videos asks for confirmation first.

A link to a video that was opened from a playlist brings the whole playlist while "Download whole playlists" is checked, as it is by default. With the option unchecked, a card in the window asks each time whether to download only that video or the whole playlist. The app remembers the setting. Other links download as they are, one video each.

Some tag pages that group several posts, each with an embedded video, are read the same way: one row per post, from the oldest to the newest, so a series keeps its episode order.

Formats

Format	Result	yt-dlp options
Video	MP4 with H.264 and AAC, at the highest resolution available in H.264	`-f bv*+ba/b -S vcodec:h264,res,acodec:aac --merge-output-format mp4`
Audio only	MP3 at the highest quality	`-x --audio-format mp3 --audio-quality 0`

H.264 is preferred because every Windows player handles it. Files are named after the video title.

Repository layout

Path	Contents
`fuentes/Haul/`	App source code (C#, WPF on .NET 10)
`fuentes/Haul/Core/`	Queue, playlists, links, settings and the yt-dlp process
`icono/icono.html`	Icon as SVG, shared with the macOS version
`icono/icono-1024.png`, `icono/icono-256.png`, `icono/Haul.ico`	Rendered icon and the Windows icon file
`installer/Msi/`	The MSI package (WiX)
`installer/SetupUI/`	The setup window, in English and Spanish (.NET Framework 4.7.2, WPF), which also runs winget
`installer/Setup/`	The setup program that carries the setup window and the MSI (WiX bundle)
`scripts/build.ps1`	Checks the bundled yt-dlp and builds Haul, `haul.msi` and `haul-setup.exe` into `dist\`
`scripts/actualizar-yt-dlp.ps1`	Replaces the bundled yt-dlp with another verified release
`scripts/extraer_licencias.py`	Reads the third-party licenses stored inside `yt-dlp.exe`
`scripts/manual.sh`	Builds the PDF manuals and `README.txt`, `README.es.txt` from the READMEs (on macOS, with pandoc and Google Chrome)
`plugins/haul/`	Haul's own yt-dlp extractor plugin, for links the bundled version does not handle
`vendor/yt-dlp/`	Bundled copy of yt-dlp 2026.08.19, with sources, checksums, signature and licenses
`docs/Haul-manual-en.pdf`, `docs/Haul-manual-es.pdf`	PDF manuals, in English and Spanish
`docs/manual.css`	Stylesheet for the manuals
`README.md`, `README.es.md`	This documentation, in English and Spanish
`README.txt`, `README.es.txt`	Plain-text copies that the installer puts next to `Haul.exe`
`CHANGELOG.md`	Version history

The `build\` and `dist\` folders and the compiler's `bin\` and `obj\` folders are generated and are not part of the repository.

To build from source, with the .NET 10 SDK installed:

```
git clone https://github.com/Gabriel-Castiglia/haul-windows.git
cd haul-windows
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File scripts\build.ps1
```

`build.ps1` refuses to build if the bundled `yt-dlp.exe` does not match its official checksums. It publishes Haul as a self-contained `Haul.exe` with `yt-dlp.exe`, `plugins\` and `licenses\` next to it, and builds `dist\haul.msi` and `dist\haul-setup.exe`; the WiX Toolset is restored automatically as a NuGet package. The version is set in one place, `fuentes\Haul\Haul.csproj`.

Window and theme

The window cannot be made smaller than 560 × 720, so its contents always stay readable; below that height the queue scrolls, while everything above it stays fixed. Size and position are remembered between sessions. The app uses the Windows 11 Fluent theme, always in dark mode whatever the system setting, with the accent color in Settings > Personalization > Colors, also when it changes while the app is open.

Maintenance

Haul is built and tested with yt-dlp 2026.08.19, and that exact copy ships with the app. A pinned version keeps the behavior stable and does not depend on the yt-dlp repository staying online. The trade-off is that sites change often, and sooner or later a fixed version stops working with them. When that happens, a new release of Haul moves to a newer yt-dlp:

```
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File scripts\actualizar-yt-dlp.ps1 <version>
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File scripts\build.ps1
```

The first script downloads the release, verifies its signature with the key stored in `vendor\yt-dlp\public.key` (using the gpg that ships with Git for Windows) and its SHA-256 checksums, and only then replaces the files and refreshes the license texts. It needs Python to read the licenses stored inside `yt-dlp.exe`. Running the new `haul-setup.exe` also upgrades FFmpeg and Deno.

The most common yt-dlp errors are shown in plain words in the interface language (video unavailable, private video, unsupported site, missing playlist, no connection); anything else appears exactly as yt-dlp prints it.

Preferences (language, folder, format, window size, "Clear finished automatically" and "Download instrumentals") are stored in `%APPDATA%\Haul\settings.json`. Deleting that file resets them.

Technical notes

The app runs the bundled `yt-dlp.exe` as a hidden child process. An app started from the Start menu inherits the `PATH` that File Explorer had when it started, which misses tools installed afterwards with winget, so Haul rebuilds `PATH` from the registry and passes ffmpeg's location to yt-dlp. To avoid

depending on the text yt-dlp prints for a terminal, it asks for output in a custom, tab-separated format, the same as the macOS version:

Line	Contents	Source
`META`	id, channel, uploader, title and thumbnail, checked before downloading	`-O pre_process:…`
`INFO`	title, uploader, duration, thumbnail and file name	`-O before_dl:…`
`AVANCE`	percentage, speed and time remaining	`--progress-template`
`ARCHIVO`	final file path	`-O after_move:…`

Paused instrumentals are held back with `--match-filters`, so yt-dlp downloads nothing until they are allowed.

Some links fail inside yt-dlp itself, its latest release included: a video page that now asks for an account although its embedded player does not, and pages whose data moved to a different place. Haul ships a yt-dlp extractor plugin of its own in `plugins/haul/`, installed in a `plugins` folder next to `yt-dlp.exe` and passed with `--plugin-dirs`. Plugin extractors are tried before the built-in ones, and each one only matches the links it fixes. When the embedded player answers with an occasional 401 error, the plugin retries up to three times.

Playlists are read with `--flat-playlist -J`, which lists the videos without downloading them. Cancelling stops yt-dlp together with ffmpeg (the whole process tree). With `-O`, yt-dlp prints nothing else, so the files of a download are recognized by the file name in its `INFO` line: when the download starts, the app notes which files with that name already exist, and on cancelling it deletes only the new ones.

Credits

Haul is a front end; the hard work belongs to these projects:

Project	Role in Haul	License
yt-dlp, by the yt-dlp contributors, fork of youtube-dl	Download engine, bundled in `vendor/yt-dlp`	Unlicense
Components inside `yt-dlp.exe`: Python, OpenSSL, curl, curl_cffi, certifi, mutagen, websockets, brotli and others	Runtime and libraries of the Windows executable	Their own licenses, listed in `vendor/yt-dlp/licenses/yt-dlp-exe-THIRD_PARTY_LICENSES.txt`
yt-dlp-ejs, included in yt-dlp	JavaScript challenge solver	Unlicense
meriyah, by KFlash and others, inside yt-dlp-ejs	JavaScript parser	ISC
astring, by David Bonnet, inside yt-dlp-ejs	JavaScript code generator	MIT
FFmpeg, build by the yt-dlp project, installed with winget, not bundled	Merges picture and sound, converts to MP3	GPL-3.0+ for this build
Deno, installed with winget	JavaScript runtime used by yt-dlp	MIT
.NET and WPF, inside `Haul.exe`	Runtime and user interface framework	MIT
WiX Toolset, only to build the installers	MSI package and setup program	MS-RL
Segoe Fluent Icons, part of Windows	Icons of the interface	Windows license
pandoc, only to build the PDF manuals	Markdown to HTML conversion	GPL-2.0+

The license texts of the bundled components are in `vendor/yt-dlp/licenses/` and are installed next to the app, under `licenses\`.

License

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Haul includes an unmodified copy of yt-dlp in `vendor/yt-dlp`, which keeps its own licenses (Unlicense, plus the licenses of the components inside `yt-dlp.exe`) and is not covered by the GPL. Haul runs yt-dlp and ffmpeg as separate programs and does not link to them; ffmpeg is not bundled.